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Taking Shape: on the Current Constellation of (Religious) Thought

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In assessing the status of contemporary religious thought, many scholars and theologians would focus solely on idealities of discourse and ignore the no less crucial material conditions of thinking. I am not interested in positing a dualism here, nor do I wish to reduce the former to the latter, but rather I would like to reflect on the space of religious thinking, which at its limit calls into question the very opposition between material and ideal. At present, two situations over-determine the shape of academic religious or theological discourse in a critical manner: a new variety of positivism, which expresses in part a conservative entrenchment responding to financial and ideological threats to the modern university; and a no less problematic politics of representation, which deploys a positivistic logic in order to promote self-interested agendas that are understood to completely coincide with intellectual exploration, without remainder.

Transforming Religious Thought

The New Positivism [^1]

The Politics of Representation

Ethics and the Place of Theory

Notes

Clayton Crockett is the author of *A Theology of the Sublime*, editor of *Secular Theology: American Radical Theological Thought*, and editor of the *Journal for Cultural and Religious Theory*. He teaches Religion and Philosophy at Wesley College in Dover, Delaware.

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